

Golden Gate National Recreation Area - Visitor Guide

Destination: Golden Gate National Recreation Area, San Francisco Bay Area, California

Overview

Golden Gate National Recreation Area begins where the Pacific Ocean meets San Francisco Bay. Established in 1972, it has grown to more than 75,000 acres and is recognized by the United Nations as the Golden Gate Biosphere Reserve. The park spans well-known destinations such as Alcatraz and Muir Woods, as well as quiet, less-visited areas.

Planning Your Visit - If you have an hour

Walk the Esplanade at Ocean Beach. Stroll through the Great Meadow at Fort Mason. Watch ships at Fort Baker's Battery Yates. Watch the sunset at Cliff House. Tour the visitor center at the Presidio. Walk beside restored coastal habitat at Crissy Field. Hike along the old railroad bed at Lands End. Watch swimmers at Aquatic Park. Tour the Nike Missile Site in the Marin Headlands.

Planning Your Visit - Two or three hours

Look for migratory birds of prey soaring above Marin Headlands on Hawk Hill (best in fall). Visit the Bay Area Discovery Museum. Spot whales at Muir Beach Overlook during their winter migration (December-February). Hike to the Point Bonita Lighthouse (limited hours). Take a wildflower walk at Fort Funston (in spring). Bicycle through the Presidio. Take a walking tour of the Cliff House area. Listen to voices from California's past at the Marin Headlands Visitor Center. Walk through the redwood forest at Muir Woods.

Planning Your Visit - Half day

Hike through the Phleger Estate. Mountain bike on Mount Tamalpais. Hike through the hills at Marin Headlands. Kayak in Tomales Bay. Hike, bicycle, or ride a horse on the Tennessee Valley Trail. Fish at Fort Point, Baker Beach, or Ocean Beach. Hike the Rift Zone Trail in Olema Valley. Take the ferry to Alcatraz (reserve ahead). Hike to the San Francisco Bay Discovery Site at Sweeney Ridge. Walk from Fort Mason to Fort Point, across the Golden Gate Bridge, to Sausalito, and return by ferry.

Hidden Gems

Olema Valley: Follow Highway 1 or the Rift Zone Trail along the San Andreas Fault Zone from Tomales Bay to Bolinas Lagoon. Ridgetop trails have spectacular ocean views. Bolinas Lagoon: Look for birds and marine mammals in this rich wetland habitat. Nearby Audubon Canyon Ranch is home to great egrets and great blue herons. Milagra Ridge: Habitat restoration site for the endangered Mission blue butterfly, with quiet coastal views away from the crowds. Sweeney Ridge: From this ridgetop in 1769, a scouting party under Gaspar de Portola became the first Europeans to see San Francisco Bay. A monument marks the approximate location. Phleger Estate: A 1,300-acre site, home to the Phleger family starting in the 1930s, accessible from Huddart County Park near Woodside.

Getting There and Around

Most sites are less than an hour's drive from San Francisco. San Francisco's Municipal Railway (MUNI) has bus and trolley service to most park sites in San Francisco. MUNI lines connect to Golden Gate Transit in Marin County, Bay Area Rapid Transit (BART) and AC Transit in the East Bay, and CalTrain and SamTrans in the Peninsula area. Ferries serve Alcatraz and Angel Island State Park. Bus service is not available to most park destinations in Marin and San Mateo counties.

Local Tips and Safety

Dogs on leashes are allowed in most areas of the park; check locally for regulations and clean up waste. Check tide tables before walking on isolated beaches, since rising water can trap you against a cliff with no escape route. Be prepared for sudden and extreme weather changes and wear layered clothing. Carry plenty of water when hiking. Coastal cliffs may crumble and slide, so keep away from the edges. Watch out for poison oak. Swimming is not recommended in most park waters because ocean currents off the coast are dangerous.

FAQ: What are the must-see destinations?

Alcatraz Island: A Civil War-era artillery post converted to a federal maximum-security penitentiary that operated from 1934 to 1963. Access is by tour boat only; reservations are required well in advance. Angel Island: A 740-acre California State Park reachable by ferry from San Francisco and Tiburon. Site of the Angel Island Immigration Station, once the point of entry for thousands of Asian and European immigrants. Muir Woods National Monument: An old-growth stand of coastal redwoods with a visitor center and paved, level walking paths as well as hiking trails. Expect large crowds and very limited parking; an entrance fee applies. Muir Beach Overlook: Site of a former U.S. Army coastal observation post with spectacular coastal views; a good spot to watch migrating whales in winter. Tennessee Valley: A well-maintained 1.7-mile trail popular with hikers, cyclists, and horseback riders, leading past a quiet lagoon to a remote black-sand beach. Marin Headlands: Explore historic military structures, including a Cold War-era Nike missile site, and hike out to the Point Bonita Lighthouse where bay meets ocean. Fort Point National Historic Site: The only Civil War-era casemated fort on the West Coast; it never saw combat and was spared demolition during construction of the Golden Gate Bridge. Lands End: Famous for ocean views; look for shipwrecks at

low tide. The USS San Francisco Memorial honors those who fought in the WWII Battle of Guadalcanal. Ocean Beach: A wild, windy beach stretching four miles from Cliff House to Fort Funston. Cold water and rip currents make swimming extremely dangerous. Fort Funston: Continuous strong winds make these coastal headlands ideal for hang-gliding; wildflowers abound in spring.

FAQ: Is the park accessible for visitors with disabilities?

Individual site listings on the park brochure give specific accessibility information. Call the park's accessibility line for additional information before planning a visit to a specific site.

FAQ: Who do I contact in an emergency?

In an emergency, dial 911 or call the Park Communications Center at 415-561-5656.